

Then there's the alert message itself. In our case in Figure 5E, that's "The item 'Teach' already exists. Replace this item?" Notice that the message tells us what has happened and also asks us what we want to do.

Using Buttons

We respond via the oval buttons at the bottom of the alert. Click one of these buttons with the mouse to tell the computer what to do. In this case, we can Cancel the operation, or we can Replace the existing program with the one we're moving. A few words have specific meanings when you see them in alerts like this. For example:

- "OK" (or "Okay") means that you acknowledge the information the computer is presenting and that it's all right to continue.
- "Continue" means basically the same thing as "OK" but is usually used in a sense of giving the computer permission to perform an operation after it has asked if it's all right to do so (as opposed to "OK," which is usually just an acknowledgement to a Note or Stop alert).
- "Cancel" means that you want the computer to put things back exactly the way they were before you started the operation, as if you never selected it. For example, if you choose to initialize a disk and then click the Cancel button before the initialization begins, the disk is not initialized and no information is lost. (In the case of the situation depicted in Figure 5E, the move would never happen.)
- "Stop" means to stop the operation in progress. Unlike "Cancel," the operation may be partially complete. For example, if you're doing a search and replace operation in a word processor, you may be able to stop the replace operation, but not cancel it, if you've already accepted some changes. If you see a "Stop" button, but not a "Cancel" button, the computer has already completed at least part of the operation.

Shortcut

One of the buttons usually has a double outline, like the "Replace" button in our example. Pressing the Return key is the same as clicking the double-outlined, or default, button. Pressing - (holding Apple and pressing the period key) or pressing Escape is the same as clicking the Cancel button, if there is one.

⑥ New & Improved

In System 6, you can now click most alert buttons from the keyboard by pressing the first letter of the button's name (excluding double-outlined buttons and the Cancel button, which have their own keyboard equivalents).